

Hook Document - Does Crisis Change the Conversation?

GitHub Repository: https://github.com/taranaahad5-hue/DS4002.CS3_SOTU_Case_Study

Every year, the President of the United States stands before Congress and delivers the State of the Union address. It's one of the most-watched political speeches in the country, a moment where the President sets the tone for the year ahead. During the Great Depression, FDR told Americans they had nothing to fear but fear itself. During COVID, presidents urged resilience. During wars, they called for unity. But here's the question: does the tone of these speeches actually change when the country is in crisis, or does the President choose to stay optimistic during challenging times?

You are stepping into the role of a political data scientist tasked with answering exactly that. You'll be working with a dataset of every State of the Union address since 1850, spanning wars, recessions, pandemics, and periods of relative calm. Your mission is to determine whether presidents speak differently during times of national crisis or whether the rhetoric stays relentlessly optimistic, no matter what is happening in the world.

To do this, you'll need to make some real judgment calls. What even counts as a national crisis? How do you draw the line between a crisis year and a stable one? How do you measure optimism in a speech that was written to inspire? These are not just technical questions; they are the kinds of decisions that shape what your data actually means.

Once you have worked through those decisions, you'll run your analysis, compare results across crisis and non-crisis periods, and draw your own conclusions. Does crisis change the way presidents talk to the American people, or does the show always go on?

All materials, including data, scripts, and instructions, can be found in the GitHub repository linked above.



Image Source: <https://www.cnn.com/2023/02/03/politics/gallery/history-state-of-the-union-photos>